

Routers above ₹8,000

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ASUS	ZyXEL	Netgear	Dlink
RT-N56U	NGB-460N	WNDR3700	DIR-685
8500	9600	10915	12399
Stunning looking	Looks nice, good menus	Great build quality	2.5" HDD bay, LCD display
Performance doesn't match looks	Expensive	Very poor performer, overpriced	Poor performance
16.2	15	16.4	16.6
6.28	6.24	6.41	7.52
31.92	37.42	23.19	25.25
54.40	58.66	46.00	49.37
802.11n	802.11n	802.11n	802.11n
Ethernet	Ethernet	Ethernet	Ethernet
4	4	4	4
2	0	1	2
Y	N	Y	N
Y / Y / Y	Y / Y / Y	Y / Y / Y	Y / Y / Y
Y / N	Y / Y	Y / Y	Y / N
N	Y	Y	Y
N	N	N	N
WPA 2 personal, WPA 2 Enterprise	WPA 2 personal, WPA 2 Enterprise	WPA 2 personal, WPA 2 Enterprise	WPA 2 personal, WPA 2 Enterprise
Y	Y	Y	Y
Y	Y	Y	Y
Y	Y	Y	Y
7.25	7.5	7.5	7.75
7.5	7.5	8	8
8	8	7.75	7.5
8	8	8	7.5
3.74	8.28	11.83	5.29
4.44	9.94	8.15	5.34
3.50	6.37	4.18	2.31
3.60	5.65	6.29	2.52
1.86	3.31	0.00	1.09
1.98	1.18	0.00	1.17
4.65	11.23	5.87	3.81
4.78	5.35	3.06	2.72
2.04	0.02	0.20	0.83
8.75	9	8.75	8.5
7.75	7.5	7.5	7.25
7.5	5	1	7

wagon, but they didn't and this is still unique. Secondly, it's actually almost a router only on second thought – you can use it as a torrent download box, a photo frame, and add customised widget-like apps to display weather, Flickr photos, Tweets, and much more. However, since we didn't award any

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Belkin Play

points for all these extra features – because we're testing routers, not gizmos – it seemed only fair to give this router our coveted Editor's Pick award. After all, to remain unique two years after launch is almost unheard of in the tech world!

The most plain-jane router in terms of features was the ZyXEL NGB-460N – it didn't feature a USB port, neither did it have dual radios. What ZyXEL did get right was the firmware interface that was quite a pleasure to use – simple and well laid out with nice explanations for each setting. Netgear's WNDR3700 is a large router that is nonetheless attractive looking with its neat stand and transparent plastic bezel over the embedded LEDs.

Performance

Sadly, one cannot test the combined speed of both radios on dual simultaneous routers else we'd break some records.

Equally sadly, with the exception of the Belkin Play, none of these routers were really consistent throughout the zones. Take the Netgear WNDR3700 for example – a brilliant score of 11.83 megabytes per second in zone one, and then failing in zone three. Or the mighty Linksys E3000 that barely managed to transfer one megabyte per second in zone three. The cheaper TPLink routers in the previous category blow away these heavy hitters in terms of sheer performance. However, it is true that if one utilises both wireless radios, you do get two relatively steady parallel streams of the same speed, however, it is not the same stream. ZyXEL's NGB-460N was the next most consistent after the Belkin Play, but the Best Buy award goes to the Belkin Play – consistent scores, 2 USB ports and at a price of ₹8,199 (MRP) which was the lowest in this category.

CLOSING THOUGHTS

If anything, this test proved quite interesting. For one, the costliest routers weren't the fastest. Two – it's not everyday that a newcomer impresses, and TPLink, a Chinese brand that does a lot of business in Hong Kong did just that. But if anything this test reiterated our belief in the fickle nature of wireless networks. The fact that an 802.11g router can close in and surpass an 802.11n one showcases either the failure of a new protocol, or the very nature of fluctuating and attenuation-prone wireless signals, and poor quality antennas.

The latest crop of routers that have been announced feature maximum theoretical speeds up to 450 megabits per second. We'll have to wait and see if those can live up to expectations. Let's meet back here again, next time, to find out? **[1]**